Group Discussions



SVNIT 2024

Group Communication



~ Many-to-many communication

~ Teamwork and group communication

~ Open organizational climate and participative management.



Team: Objective is set; members are assigned specific duties to achieve a specific goal;

Group: Involved in discussing and planning the achievement of long-term goals.

Purpose

- Share and exchange information and ideas.
- Collect information or feedback.
- Arrive at a decision.
- Solve a problem.
- Discuss issues involving the group itself.
- Elicit feedback upon any work undertaken.

- Depending on the purpose, structure, and characteristics, group communication takes various names such as discussion, meeting, conference, seminar, group discussion, symposium, convention, etc.

Name	Purpose/objective	Structure	Characteristics	Procedure
Meeting	• To convey information to a group of people • To instruct, brief, make decisions, solve problems	• Two or more persons to several hundreds • Formal physical setting	• Punctuality • Presided by a chairman • Started with an introduction Problem-centred • Discussion-oriented • Information-centred • Fair chance to everyone • May be periodic • No side conversations • No hidden agenda • High degree of formality • Ends with a conclusion	• Notice given • Agenda prepared • Minutes recorded
Seminar	• To present the results of an original research or advanced study/ evaluation of ideas • To share knowledge, and viewpoints	• Small groups of experts or well-informed persons	• Academic in nature • Close interaction with lead speaker • Free discussion	• Presentation of a topi • Discussion

Name	Purpose/objective	Structure	Characteristics	Procedure
Group discussion	• To exchange information • To solve problems • To convince • To make decisions • To assess or judge personality traits	• Seven to ten	• No named leader • Minimal rules • Free verbal interaction • Interdependent • Impersonal • Conclusive	• Comprehension • Discussion • Conclusion
Symposium	• To discuss different aspects of a problem for an audience	• Any number	• Formal • For larger audience	• Presentation of an aspect by each participant • Audience participation
Panel discussion	• To exchange ideas through conversation and cooperative thinking	• Small number of panelists (experts)	• Moderator present • Meant for public discussion • Includes programmes on radio and TV • Less formal than meetings	• Problem/topic put across as a question • Answers given by panelists
Conference		• Any number of participants • Wider subject matter • Several sessions		• Presentations • Discussion
Convention	• To discuss matters of professional interest	• Rigorously structured • Professional gatherings of companies, associations, societies, political parties, etc.	• Formal • Issues associated with the particular profession	• Sharing of views

Group Discussions

- Interactive personality test for evaluating several candidates:

I. Personnel for positions of responsibility

II. Students for admission to professional institutes

- Characteristics evaluated:

1. Leadership skills
2. Group behaviour, orientation, and management
3. Communication skills
4. Reasoning, analytical abilities, logical thinking
5. Orderly conduct, cooperation, and respecting others' viewpoints
6. Time-sharing
7. Likeable personality: Descent dressing and assertive body language



https://iconscout.com/illustrations/group-discussion

Types of Group Discussions

I. Topic-based:

a. Factual Topics

b. Controversial Topics

c. Abstract Topics

II. Case-based



Factual Topics



- Factual topics are about practical things, which an ordinary person is aware of in his day-to-day life – Socio-economic topics.
- Current topics, i.e., they may have been in the news lately or could be unbound by time.
- A factual topic for discussion gives a candidate a chance to prove that s/he is aware of and sensitive to his environment.
- **Examples**: The education policy of India, Tourism in India, State of the aged in the nation.

Controversial Topics

- Controversial topics are the ones that are argumentative in nature.
- They are meant to generate controversy.
- In GDs where these topics are given for discussion, the noise level is usually high, there may be tempers flying.
- The idea behind giving a topic like this is to gauge the maturity level of the candidate who rationally and logically argues her/his point of view without getting personal and emotional.
- **Example**: Reservations should be removed.



Abstract Topics

- Abstract topics are about intangible things.
- These topics are not given often for discussion, but their possibility cannot be ruled out.
- These topics test your lateral thinking and creativity of the candidate
- **Examples**: A is an alphabet, Twinkle twinkle little star, The number 10



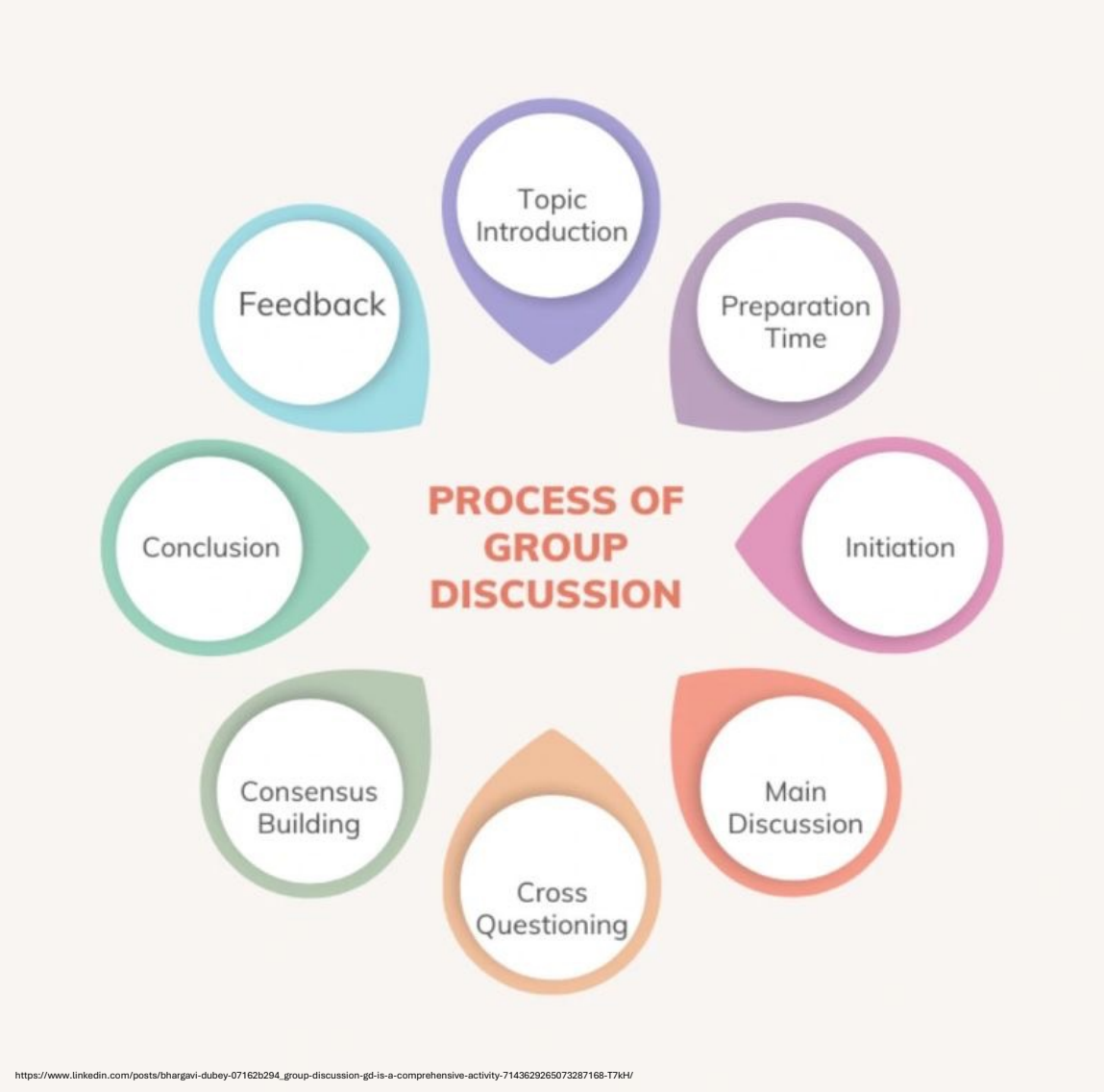
Case-based Group Discussion

- In case studies, a short description of a situation (called a "case") is given to all the participants.
- The case will typically be a problem situation that requires a solution.
- The participants must study the case, analyze the problem, and then discuss various situations to the problem.



Example: "A software engineer is hired as a trainee by a company that specializes in hardware. As the end of his mandatory training period approaches, his job performance is found below par, and he is informed that he must leave the company at the end of his training period. His immediate superior, out of kindness, writes him a recommendation letter, which may help him in getting the next job. However, this engineer uses the letter to take the company to court and challenges his dismissal. How should the company resolve this situation?"

Major Functions of a Participant and the Process



https://www.linkedin.com/posts/bhargavi-dubey-07162b294_group-discussion-gd-is-a-comprehensive-activity-7143629265073287168-T7kH/

Functions

- Introducing Oneself/Others
- Expressing Opinions and Ideas
- Expressing Agreement/Disagreement
- Raising Questions
- Giving and Receiving Effective Feedback
- Concluding

Strategies in Group Discussion

- Speaking in Group Discussions
- Discussing Problems and Solutions
- Creating a Cordial and Cooperative Atmosphere
- Being Polite and Firm
- Using Persuasive Strategies
- Turn Taking Strategies
- Effective Intervention
- Reaching a Decision

- Seize the first opportunity to speak if you have a good understanding of the topic
- Listen patiently to others before reacting
- Speak clearly and raise your voice to be audible
- Be concise in your expressions. Define concepts to dispel ambiguity. Do not repeat ideas
- Avoid technical words, obsolete expressions, colloquialisms.
- Connotative words should be used with caution.
- Sound natural. Speak with enthusiasm and conviction

- To discuss problems and get to their solution, it is necessary to question

Example: Questions may be raised for various purposes, such as to get more information, to paraphrase, to raise a doubt, to make an offer, to seek permission,

Discussing Problems and Solutions

- Ask for clarification, if necessary.
- Facilitate contribution from others.
- Avoid talking to only one or two persons
- Assume an impersonal tone. None in the group is either a friend or a foe

Example: Avoid titles such as Mr, Ms, Dr, or Prof. while introducing oneself, but use them while introducing others

Creating a Cordial and Cooperative Atmosphere

- Agreement can be expressed easily with words such as exactly, right, yes, etc.,
- Disagreement must be expressed politely using 'I am not so sure, Do you think so?, well, it depends, etc.', with controlled body language.
- Giving Feedback:

specific, accurate, good intentions, right time

- Receiving Feedback:

LISTEN, Be open-minded, accept if comments are true-explain if not, ask the other participants' views, appreciate the people who have provided feedback, don't be judgemental

Example:

Although it is true that stopping the use of mobile phones may have some advantages, I do not think it is a good idea. **(strong disagreement)**

While I agree that stopping the use of mobile phones may have some advantages, I feel that we should discuss it thoroughly. **(polite disagreement)**

Being Polite

- Always use evidence (statistics/examples/testimonies) to justify your views.
- Establish mutual respect and win the confidence of others.
- While expressing an opinion, we can follow the ORE (opinion, reason, example) pattern as shown in the sample below:

- Example: (move to the next slide)

Using Persuasive Strategies

&

Effective intervention

X: What do you think about stopping the use of mobile phones in our college?

YOU: I think/In my opinion, it is not a good idea/I don't think it is a good idea (O).

Y: Why ?

YOU: I feel that/My view is that mobile phones serve as the best tool to be in touch with others in college (R).

X: Why do you want to be in touch through mobile phone when all your friends are available in college?

YOU: Say, I am in the library and I want to ask my friend who is not with me about some information about the contents of a book or say my parents want to contact me urgently, they can send me a message or talk to me if I am free (E).

- **Taking a turn:** Being ready to speak when one finishes is taking one's turn.
- For instance, if you respond to some member by agreeing, disagreeing, posing a query, or by paraphrasing what was said, you are taking a turn.
- **Holding the turn:** There may be members in a group who do not wish to give turns to others to speak. They may like to keep the turn to themselves and continue further. Hence, they may suppress their verbal and non-verbal cues that are used to tell others to take their turn.
- **Yielding the turn:** When we give cues to indicate that we are concluding our remarks and others can take up the discussion further, we are yielding the turn.

Turn-taking Strategies

- Thank everybody for contributing significantly to the discussion goal.
- Mention the most significant points raised by certain participants, thereby recognizing their contribution to the decision-making process.
- Summarize the major points

Reaching a Decision



Group Discussion as a Part of Selection Process

- Selection/elimination of candidates
- Simulated managerial setting.

Characteristics:

- Unstructured
- Leaderless
- No Examiner
- 8 to 10 participants
- 15-30 Minutes

Evaluation and Analysis

Knowledge

- Depth and range
- Originality of ideas
- Common sense
- Conceptualizing the topic

Communication Skills

- Active listening
- Clarity of expression
- Apt language – Discussion killers and discussion ignitors
- Appropriate body language

Body Language

Every participant's body language is noticed – speakers' and listeners'

- Eye contact
- Facial expressions showing interest
- Restrain emotional expressions
- Small hand gestures
- Change in posture while sitting
- Observe the non-verbal cues

Body language signal	Intended meaning/interpretation
• Tilted head	• Interest
• Drumming fingers/tapping foot	• Impatience
• Drooping shoulders	• Lack of interest
• Open palms	• Sincerity, openness/candidness
• Folded arms	• Complaint/nervousness/feel threatened/ disagreement
• Slumped posture, looking away	• Suppressed anger or irritation
• Staring	• Attention seeking/aggression
• Hand-wringing	• Acute anxiety/worry/tension/stress/need for sympathy
• Pointing fingers at you while talking	• Complaint/aggression/anger/frustration
• Nodding while listening	• Agreeing/signalling understanding
• Head rubbing	• Puzzled/stumped by question
• Frowning	• Intense listening/potential disagreement/confused/need more detail
• Fiddling with accessories/jewellery	• Discomfort/embarrassment/stress/in need of second opinion
• Looking down to the left	• Having conversation with themselves
• Narrowing eyes	• Disbelief/anger
• Raised eyebrows	• Sarcastic/disbelief/smug
• Smiling/leaning forward/eye contact	• Friendly/interested
• Hand to cheek	• Evaluating/thinking
• Head resting in hands with eyes looking down	• Boredom, not interested
• Steepled fingers	• Authoritative/feeling superior
• Hands covering mouth or face/rapid blinking/little use of eye contact	• Shy
• Leaning back in chair with hands clasped behind head	• Overconfident/arrogant/wanting to belittle you

Group Behavior

- **Roles**

Initiator, Informer, Illustrator, Leader, Coordinator, and Moderator

- Group dynamic and ability to interact
- Emotional maturity and balance
- People-centric – being considerate

Leadership skills

- Coordinating abilities: Group adaptability and group motivation

Styles:

Authoritative, Amiable, Democratic

- Control the "fish-market" environment during a GD

Organizational GD

Brainstorming

- Wide range of people
- No criticism

Steps:

1. Introduce topic
2. Discuss alternatives
3. Jot them down together

Types:

I. Storyboarding

II. Lotus Blossom Technique

Nominal Group Technique

- Participants operate individually

Steps:

1. Introduce topic
2. Individually write each idea
3. One after the other presents
4. All participants rank ideas
5. Decision: Highest ranking idea

Delphi Technique

- Time consuming
- No physical presence

Steps:

1. Introduce problem
2. 1st questionnaire solutions
3. Results compile and present
4. 2nd questionnaire solution
5. Repeat 3 & 4 until final consensus

Thank You

Reference: *Technical Communication* by Meenakshi Raman and Sangeeta Sharma